

NEIGHBORHOOD WATCH PROGRAM

Area Coordinator Code of Conduct

Effective Date: _____ Version: 1.0

PREFACE

The Neighborhood Watch Program is a community-based public safety initiative that depends on the goodwill, integrity, and professionalism of its volunteer Area Coordinators. This Code of Conduct establishes clear expectations for how Area Coordinators carry out their responsibilities, represent themselves and the program, interact with neighbors, public officials, and partner agencies, and conduct themselves both in person and online.

Every Area Coordinator is a volunteer. In that capacity, they do not speak on behalf of, nor have any authority to represent, any law enforcement agency, government body, or other organization unless explicitly and formally authorized to do so in writing. Adherence to this Code of Conduct is a condition of serving as an Area Coordinator.

1. ROLE AND SCOPE OF THE AREA COORDINATOR

1.1 What an Area Coordinator Is

- A volunteer community liaison who facilitates communication and awareness within a defined geographic area.
- A point of contact who encourages neighbors to look out for one another and report suspicious activity through proper channels.
- An organizer of community engagement activities such as meetings, newsletters, and safety awareness campaigns.

1.2 What an Area Coordinator Is Not

- A law enforcement officer, agent, or official representative of any police department or public safety agency.
- A spokesperson for any government agency, city department, or elected official.
- An investigator, enforcer, or authority figure with power to detain, question, or compel any person.
- A representative of any child welfare or child safeguarding organization (including, but not limited to, any entity responsible for children's programs such as enabling or protective services for minors).
- A legal advisor, mediator, or dispute resolution authority.

2. INTEGRITY AND ETHICAL CONDUCT

2.1 Honesty and Transparency

- Area Coordinators must be truthful at all times when communicating with neighbors, officials, and partner organizations.

- Coordinators must not misrepresent facts, fabricate incidents, or exaggerate reports for any purpose.
- Coordinators must accurately represent their role and authority, especially when speaking with members of the public who may assume they hold official status.

2.2 Conflicts of Interest

- Coordinators must disclose any personal, financial, or political conflicts of interest that may affect their judgment or impartiality.
- Coordinators may not use their position to advance personal business, political, or financial interests.
- Coordinators must recuse themselves from any matter in which they have a direct personal stake.

2.3 Non-Discrimination

- Coordinators must treat all residents with equal dignity and respect, without discrimination based on race, color, ethnicity, national origin, religion, gender, sexual orientation, age, disability, income, or any other protected characteristic.
- Coordinators must not engage in, encourage, or tolerate profiling of any individual or group based on protected characteristics.
- Suspicious activity reports must always be based on specific, observed behaviors — never on appearance, identity, or demographics alone.

3. SOCIAL MEDIA AND ONLINE COMMUNICATIONS

3.1 Personal vs. Official Representation

- When posting on any personal social media account, profile, or platform, an Area Coordinator speaks solely for themselves as a private individual — not on behalf of the Neighborhood Watch program, any other Area Coordinator, the police department, or any government agency.
- Personal opinions expressed online must never be presented as the official position or policy of the Neighborhood Watch program.
- Area Coordinators must include a clear disclaimer on any personal social media account that is publicly associated with their Neighborhood Watch role, such as: "Posts and opinions are my own and do not represent the Neighborhood Watch program, law enforcement, or any government agency."

3.2 Official Program Accounts

- Only those explicitly authorized by program leadership may post on official Neighborhood Watch social media pages or group accounts.
- All posts on official accounts must be factual, neutral in tone, and reviewed in accordance with program guidelines before publication.
- Official accounts must not be used to advance personal opinions, political viewpoints, or commentary on individual residents.

3.3 Prohibited Online Conduct

- Coordinators must not post identifying information, photos, or videos of individuals suspected of wrongdoing without the explicit authorization of law enforcement.
- Coordinators must not post content that is defamatory, harassing, threatening, or that invades the privacy of any individual.

- Coordinators must not share unverified rumors, speculation, or misinformation, particularly regarding criminal incidents or suspects.
- Coordinators must not use social media to publicly criticize, shame, or target any neighbor, resident, or public official by name.
- Coordinators must not make statements that could be construed as speaking on behalf of law enforcement, including sharing details of active investigations or pending police actions.
- Coordinators must not impersonate any agency, official, or fellow coordinator online.

3.4 Responsible Sharing

- Before sharing crime alerts, safety notices, or incident reports online, Coordinators must verify the information through official sources (police department, city communications) where possible.
- If shared information is later found to be inaccurate, Coordinators must promptly correct or retract it.

4. RELATIONSHIP WITH LAW ENFORCEMENT

4.1 Cooperation, Not Authority

- Area Coordinators serve as a bridge between the community and law enforcement — they are not an extension of police authority.
- Coordinators must direct all criminal activity or safety threats to law enforcement immediately and must not attempt to intervene in or investigate incidents personally.
- Coordinators must never represent to any resident, suspect, or party that they are acting in a law enforcement capacity.

4.2 Reporting Obligations

- All reports of suspicious or criminal activity must be directed to the appropriate emergency or non-emergency law enforcement line. Coordinators are not the recipient of formal complaints.
- Coordinators must not promise residents any specific police response, action, or outcome.
- Coordinators must not share sensitive details of police operations, investigations, or personnel matters with any party.

5. CHILDREN, MINORS, AND CHILD SAFEGUARDING

5.1 Clear Boundaries of Authority

- Area Coordinators do not represent, act on behalf of, or speak for any child welfare, child protective, or children's program organization, including any programs specifically focused on enabling or safeguarding services for minors.
- Coordinators have no authority to intervene in, investigate, or mediate any matter involving the welfare, custody, or safety of minors on behalf of any agency.
- Any concern regarding the welfare or safety of a child must be reported directly to the appropriate child protective services or law enforcement agency — not handled by the Area Coordinator.

5.2 Safeguarding in Program Activities

- Coordinators must never be alone with a minor in a private or enclosed setting during any Neighborhood Watch activity.
- Coordinators must not collect, store, or share personal information about minors without the explicit written consent of a parent or legal guardian.
- Any Neighborhood Watch event or activity involving minors must have appropriate adult supervision as required by program policy and local law.

6. PRIVACY AND CONFIDENTIALITY

- Coordinators must safeguard all personal information shared by residents, including names, addresses, contact details, and reports of incidents, and may only use such information for authorized Neighborhood Watch purposes.
- Resident information may not be shared with third parties, including other neighbors, businesses, or media, without the express consent of the individual concerned.
- Coordinators must not maintain unauthorized databases or lists of individuals they personally deem suspicious.
- Any documentation, communications, or records maintained in connection with Neighborhood Watch activities are subject to program data retention and disposal guidelines.

7. CONDUCT AT COMMUNITY EVENTS AND MEETINGS

- Coordinators must conduct all meetings and events in a welcoming, inclusive, and orderly manner.
- Political campaigning, solicitation, or promotion of personal business interests is strictly prohibited at any Neighborhood Watch event.
- Alcohol and controlled substances must not be consumed by Coordinators while they are actively performing their role.
- Coordinators must not carry, display, or make reference to personal weapons in their capacity as a Coordinator, even if legally permitted.
- Disruptive, aggressive, or confrontational behavior toward any participant is prohibited. Coordinators are expected to de-escalate tensions, not inflame them.

8. COMMUNICATIONS WITH RESIDENTS AND THE PUBLIC

- All communications must be respectful, professional, and constructive — whether verbal, written, electronic, or in person.
- Coordinators must respond to resident inquiries in a timely and courteous manner.
- Coordinators must be clear about what they can and cannot help with, and must refer residents to the appropriate agency or resource when a matter falls outside their role.
- Coordinators must not make promises or commitments on behalf of law enforcement, city government, or any other organization.
- Any formal statement or press inquiry from media must be referred immediately to the Neighborhood Watch program leadership or the designated public affairs contact. Coordinators must not speak to media on behalf of the program without explicit authorization.

9. REPORTING CONCERNS WITHIN THE PROGRAM

- Coordinators are encouraged to raise concerns about program activities, fellow coordinators, or conduct issues in good faith through the appropriate program leadership channel.
- Retaliation against any person who raises a concern in good faith is strictly prohibited.
- Coordinators who become aware of conduct that may constitute a crime must report it to law enforcement immediately and notify program leadership.
- Coordinators must cooperate fully with any authorized investigation into alleged misconduct.

10. CONSEQUENCES OF VIOLATIONS

Violations of this Code of Conduct may result in one or more of the following actions, depending on the nature and severity of the violation:

- Verbal or written warning.
- Mandatory remedial training.
- Temporary suspension of duties.
- Permanent removal from the Area Coordinator role.
- Referral to law enforcement where conduct may constitute a criminal offense.

All determinations regarding violations and consequences will be made by authorized program leadership, with due regard for fairness, consistency, and the evidence available.

11. ACKNOWLEDGEMENT AND AGREEMENT

By signing below, I confirm that I have read, understood, and agree to abide by this Code of Conduct in its entirety. I understand that my continued participation as a Neighborhood Watch Area Coordinator is conditional upon my ongoing compliance with these standards.

Full Name (Print): _____

Signature: _____

Area / Zone: _____

Date: _____

Witnessed / Accepted by (Program Leadership): _____

Title: _____

Date: _____

This document should be retained in the program's official records.